continue to reside calmly at Ludhiana with his family on the provision assigned to him.'[29] But it was clear to everyone that this was never going to happen.

After the fiasco of the winter raid on Kashmir, Shuja chose his moment with great care. In 1817, the feud between Afghanistan's two great families, the Barakzais and the Sadozais, had suddenly erupted again, this time following an insult by the Barakzais to a Sadozai princess. The two leading Barakzai brothers, Wazir Fatteh Khan and his younger brother Dost Mohammad, had been sent by Shah Mahmoud and his son Prince Kamran Sadozai on a mission to Herat, the most magnificent city of western Afghanistan. The brothers were to mount a surprise attack and take the great Timurid citadel from a rebellious governor who was plotting to hand it over to the Persians. This they did; but during the plundering which followed, Dost Mohammad and his followers looted the harem and there 'seized the jewelled band which fastened the trousers of the wife' of the Governor.[30] What they didn't take into account was that the Princess in question was Shah Mahmoud's niece.

A week later, when Prince Kamran arrived in Herat, he received a delegation from the harem, demanding that their honour be avenged. Like Shah Zaman before him, Kamran had begun to be worried about the growing power of the Barakzais, and seized the opportunity that the violation of the Sadozai harem presented.

A few days after his arrival in Herat, the Prince announced that he was to throw a party in the royal garden outside the fortress, and he invited Fatteh Khan and his brothers to celebrate their capture of Herat. 'Dancers and musicians gathered amidst the fruit trees, platters of kababs and decanters of red wine were prepared, and the nautch party was warming up,' wrote Mirza 'Ata.

> When the Wazir and his brothers entered the garden they drank cup after cup of wine, ate kababs and lost themselves in amazement at the dancing of the lovely women musicians of Herat. Soon they were hopelessly drunk, and the bird of sense had flown out of the Wazir's brain, and he lay befuddled. Prince Kamran had already arranged everything in advance, so at a sign all the others present at the party got up and seized the Wazir, tied his hands and feet and proceeded to blind him, drawing the tip of their daggers across his eyes to spill the clear liquid on to the dark ground of blindness.[31]

Fatteh Khan was then scalped, and brutally tortured. Sometime later he was led, blind and bleeding, into a tent where had assembled a group of his